Form Your Team

Our Team Canvas

Team _____ Date _____

1 WHY — Why are we here?

Our purpose

Why do we exist, and who is it for?

Our future

What does success look like in three years?

2 WHO — Who are we?

What does each person bring, want to develop, and need to work at their best?

3 RHYTHM — How do we work?

When do we plan, make and review? What do we do together, and what on our own time?

4 DECISION MAKING — How do we make decisions?

Which decision do we make often, and which way of deciding will we try?

5 TEAM VALUES — How do we want to be together?

IN

Behaviour that helps us do our best work

OUT

Behaviour that is not acceptable

6 EVOLVE — How do we learn and reform?

Keep

Change

Try

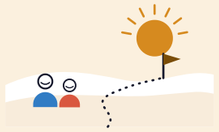
We reset this canvas when _____

Short on time? Spend ten minutes on each box and answer just its question. Take the conversations in any order.

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Conversation 1 of 6 · Why

Why are we here?



Purpose, beneficiaries and a shared picture of success.

KEY QUESTIONS

1. Who benefits from our work?
2. What difference should the team make for them?
3. What would meaningful success look like?

EXERCISES

Explain it to a friend

Pairs, then whole team · 25 min

1. In pairs, imagine explaining the team's reason for being to a friend over dinner. Speak naturally and avoid organisational language.
2. The listener does not correct or debate. They capture phrases that feel clear, human and meaningful.
3. Switch roles, then compare what was consistent and what was different.
4. Use the strongest language to create a shared purpose statement.

In three years' time...

Individual, then whole team · 30 min

1. Each person completes: "In three years' time, this team will have..." Create two or three versions individually.
2. Share without discussion and group similar ideas.
3. Vote for the statement that most unites the team and feels true, not merely the most ambitious.
4. Refine it together and identify two or three signs that would show it is becoming real.

Explain it to a friend

Phrases that felt clear, human and meaningful. One per sticky note.

Our purpose

We exist to ... for ... so that ...

In three years' time, this team will have...

Group the ideas, then vote for the one that feels true.

Signs it is becoming real

1

2

3

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Conversation 2 of 6 · Who

Who are we?



Strengths, working preferences and personal connection.

KEY QUESTIONS

1. What does each person bring?
2. How do we each work at our best?
3. What should teammates know about us beyond our role?

EXERCISES

The story behind me

Whole team · 3–4 min per person

1. Each person brings one photograph or object that says something important about them.
2. They tell the story behind it and why they chose it.
3. Listeners ask curious questions without analysing or interpreting the story.

Personal user manual

Individual, then share in pairs · 20 min

1. Each person completes their own card on their own, in their own words.
2. Share in pairs. The listener asks one question to understand better, not to challenge.
3. Bring one surprising or useful insight back to the whole team.

Skills marketplace

Individual, then whole team · 30 min

1. Each person fills in their own stall: three things they can offer the team, and one thing they want to grow in.
2. Go round the room. Each person reads their stall out loud in a minute or two.
3. Look at who could learn from whom, and agree one pairing to try in the next few weeks.

Name _____

I can offer

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I want to grow in _____

I work best when

Name _____

I can offer

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I want to grow in _____

I work best when

Name _____

I can offer

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I want to grow in _____

I work best when

Name _____

I can offer

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I want to grow in _____

I work best when

Name _____

I can offer

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I want to grow in _____

I work best when

Name _____

I can offer

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

I want to grow in _____

I work best when

The story behind me needs no paper: bring a photo or object and tell its story. Use one card per person for the user manual and the skills marketplace.

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Conversation 3 of 6 · Rhythm

How do we work?

The team's practical operating rhythm.

KEY QUESTIONS

1. When do we plan, make and review?
2. Which meetings and habits actually help us, and which can go?
3. What should we do together, and what can happen on our own time?

EXERCISE

Draw your team's loop

Whole team, at a whiteboard · 30 min

1. Draw a loop: plan → make → review → back to plan.
2. Put the meetings and habits you already have on the loop. Keep what helps, drop what doesn't.
3. For each of the three moments, agree when and how it happens, and write it above.
4. Try the rhythm for one working cycle, then adjust it together.

Plan

When? _____

How? _____



Our rhythm in one sentence

Review

When? _____

How? _____

Make

When? _____

How? _____

Habits and meetings we keep

Habits and meetings we drop

We try this rhythm until

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Conversation 4 of 6 · Decision making

How do we make decisions?



Clarity about autonomy, participation and accountability.

KEY QUESTIONS

1. Which decisions can individuals make?
2. Which decisions need input or shared ownership?
3. Which ways of deciding could we try?

EXERCISE

Choose how to decide

Whole team · 30 min

1. Each person names decisions that come up again and again. Agree on one that matters to the team.
2. Read the twelve ways to decide together. Ask what this decision needs: narrowing options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say.
3. Choose one way and try it the next few times the decision comes up.
4. Talk about how it felt, and whether to keep it or try another.

The decision we make again and again

Agree on one that matters to the team.

Twelve ways to decide · tick the one you will try

NARROW DOWN OPTIONS

- ☐ **Dot voting** A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.
- ☐ **Multi-voting** One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.
- ☐ **Scoring matrix** Every option has its own trade-offs.

DECIDE QUICKLY

- ☐ **Majority vote** There are two options and either would work.
- ☐ **Plurality** There are several options and no time for more rounds.
- ☐ **Authority** One person is accountable for the outcome.

BRING EVERYONE ALONG

- ☐ **Fist to five** People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.
- ☐ **Consensus** Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.
- ☐ **Consent** You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

SETTLE WHO HAS THE FINAL SAY

- ☐ **Supermajority** A big decision needs more than a narrow win.
- ☐ **Unanimity** Every person must actively agree before you move.
- ☐ **Delegation** The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

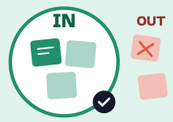
How we will decide it next time

How did it feel? Keep it or try another?

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Conversation 5 of 6 · Team values

How do we want to be together?



A practical team contract.

KEY QUESTIONS

1. What behaviour helps us do our best work?
2. What behaviour is not acceptable in this team?
3. How will we hold ourselves and each other accountable?

EXERCISE

The two-circle team contract

Whole team · 45 min

1. Draw two large circles and label them IN and OUT.
2. Add behaviours to IN that the team wants to practise and protect.
3. Add behaviours to OUT that undermine trust, inclusion or good work.
4. Talk them through, combine similar ones, and rewrite them as things someone could actually see.

IN

Behaviour we want to practise and protect

OUT

Behaviour that undermines trust, inclusion or good work

Our agreements, written so anyone could see them

When an agreement is broken, we...

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Conversation 6 of 6 · Evolve

How do we learn and reform?



Keep the team canvas alive.

KEY QUESTIONS

1. What should we protect?
2. What is no longer serving the team?
3. What change should trigger a team reset?

EXERCISE

Keep / Change / Try

Whole team · 30 min

1. Keep: What about this team should we protect?
2. Change: What is no longer helping us?
3. Try: What small experiment will we run next?
4. Agree what should make you sit down with the canvas again, for example someone joining or leaving, or the purpose changing.

Keep

What about this team should we protect?

Change

What is no longer helping us?

Try

What small experiment will we run next?

We sit down with the canvas again when...

- ☐ Someone joins or leaves
- ☐ Our purpose changes
- ☐ Responsibilities shift
- ☐ _____

Next review _____

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